

The foolproof* IP warming checklist

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Every to-do a brand needs to finish before, during, and after an IP warming project, with dates counted back from launch day.

IP warming is the slow, slightly nerve-racking process of teaching mailbox providers that your sending is safe by starting small, sending to the people who love you most, and growing volume only when the numbers say you may.

Use this list from top to bottom. Every phase is dated by counting back from launch day (Day 0), so pick your launch date and the calendar dates fill in.

A quick vocabulary note

MAGY stands for Microsoft, Apple, Google, and Yahoo. Those four are mailbox providers (the place your subscriber's inbox lives). Your ESP is the platform you send from, like Salesforce MCAE, Marketing Cloud, or HubSpot. Warming happens with the mailbox providers, so this checklist splits your list and your numbers by MAGY, and uses ESP only for the tool you send with.

Do you actually need to warm? Check this first

You need a warming plan when any of these is true: you are sending from a new dedicated IP, a new sending domain or subdomain, or a new ESP, or you are restarting after a long silence, or you plan to multiply your volume in a short time. On a shared IP pool your ESP has already warmed the pool, but a brand-new sending domain still has to earn its own reputation with Google and Microsoft. Not sure which one you are? Ask your ESP support this exact question: "Are we on a dedicated IP or a shared pool, and does our new sending domain need a warm-up plan?"



4 weeks before

Decide and get everyone on the same page

Day -28 to -22

Nothing technical yet. This week is about a written goal, one accountable person, and a send calendar that nobody else can touch.

☐

Confirm you need a warm-up (see the box above)

Get the answer from your ESP in writing: dedicated IP or shared pool, and whether the new domain needs a plan.

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Write your goal in one sentence

For example: "Reach 50,000 sends per day by [date] with complaints under 0.1%." If you cannot fill in the blanks, you are not ready to start.

☐

Name one owner and one backup for go, hold, and scale-back calls

These two people can pause a send without asking permission. Put their names at the top of your tracker.

☐

Freeze the send calendar for every team that uses this domain or IP

Sales sequences, event invites, and that "quick" newsletter all count. One unplanned send is the fastest way to wreck a ramp. Tell people now, in writing, with the end date.

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Export 6 to 12 months of send history from your ESP

You need one row per send: date, audience, delivered, unique clicks, hard bounces, unsubscribes, complaints. Next week you turn this file into your baseline click rate, the number you will hold every future send up against: a warm-up send is a success when its click rate beats that baseline, not when it beats last week's send.

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Ask your ESP what warm-up help it offers

Some platforms have automatic throttling or a daily send cap you can set. Ask your account rep or support, and send them this checklist so they know what you are planning.

☐

Start the ticket for Google Postmaster Tools access now, separately from your DNS ticket

This is worth flagging in week 1 because it is slow: every single person who needs a Postmaster dashboard has to verify against your domain individually, which usually means its own DNS record and its own IT ticket per person. If Google ever puts you in the penalty box, they are not going to call you first. They assume you were already watching Postmaster and ignored the warning signs, so this needs to be live before you send anything, not after.

3 weeks before

Measure, segment, and pick your content

Day -21 to -15

The data week. By the end you know what "good" looks like for your list, who your best subscribers are at each mailbox provider, and which emails go first.

Find your click baseline

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Clean the send history before you calculate anything

Drop tests and any send to a tiny audience. Keep sends to comparable audiences, because a webinar reminder and a cold newsletter do not share a baseline.

☐

Filter out bot clicks

Corporate security scanners click every link within seconds of delivery, and that inflates B2B click rates. If your ESP offers bot or scanner filtering, turn it on for this pull. If it does not, remove clicks that land within a few seconds of the send, or where every link was clicked in the same second.

☐

Calculate unique click rate for every send

Unique clickers divided by delivered (not sent). Do not use open rate here; Apple Mail Privacy Protection makes opens unreliable.

☐

Take the median of your last 10 to 12 comparable sends

Median, not average, so one viral send cannot drag your baseline up. This number is your baseline.

☐

Calculate it again for each mailbox provider and for your engaged segment

Your warm-up audience will be your best subscribers, so judge it against their history, not the whole database. Use the baseline calculator on the web page, or Worksheet 1 at the back of this file.

☐

Write down your success bands

Starting points, tune them for your list: Success is at or above your baseline, Watch is 75% to 99% of baseline, Concern is below 75%. A send is a success only when its click rate lands in the Success band and its complaint and bounce numbers are green.

Find your most engaged subscribers at each mailbox provider

☐

Bucket every address by mailbox provider (MAGY)

Consumer domains are easy (see the table below). Corporate domains need an MX record lookup, because a company address can sit on Google Workspace or Microsoft 365. Ask your data or ops person to run MX lookups in bulk. Anything hiding behind a gateway (Proofpoint, Mimecast) goes in its own "Corporate gateway" bucket and gets warmed on its own.

☐

Define "engaged" with clicks and real actions, never opens

Clicked a link, replied, filled out a form, visited a key page, attended an event, or bought. Opens are machine-generated for a large share of Apple Mail users, so an Apple "open" proves very little.

☐**Sort each provider's people into tiers**

Tier 1: real activity in the last 30 days. Tier 2: 31 to 90 days. Tier 3: 91 to 180 days. Parked: anything older, or never engaged. Parked people do not get mail during the warm-up.

☐**Build your suppression list and apply it to every tier**

Hard bounces, unsubscribes, past complainers, role addresses (info@, sales@, admin@), and anything from a purchased, scraped, or unverified import. Old, quiet addresses are where spam traps live.

☐**Count Tier 1 at each provider and check it covers your first two weeks**

If your Yahoo Tier 1 is 300 people, your first Yahoo sends are 300 people. That is fine. Each provider judges you separately, so spread every day's volume across all four in proportion to their share of your list.

☐**Optional: run Tier 2 and Tier 3 through an email verification service**

Cheap insurance for older segments. Do it now so the results are back before launch.

Choose the content that goes first

☐**Pull your top 5 sends by unique click rate that also had low unsubscribes and no complaint spikes**

Judge by the whole picture. A big click rate with a complaint spike is a send to avoid, not to repeat.

☐**Pick 2 or 3 evergreen pieces to rotate through weeks 1 and 2**

Content your best people already expect and like: the newsletter they ask about, your most-downloaded guide, an event follow-up. Save hard promotions and discount blasts for later.

☐**Keep every warm-up email light and clean**

Mostly text, one main call to action, two or three links, no attachments, no URL shorteners, links on your own branded tracking domain, and a plain-text version. Send from a real name people recognize, with a reply-to inbox that a human reads.

☐**Choose your "safest send" now**

Your single lowest-risk email: highest click rate, lowest complaints, no promotion. This is your fallback if you ever have to scale back, and you do not want to be choosing it in a panic.

Decide your timeline and growth percentage

☐**Choose your ramp length**

Most plans run 4 to 8 weeks, and many reach full volume in 4 to 6. A bigger target volume or a thinner engaged list pushes you longer. Use the ramp planner on the web page, or the example ramp in Worksheet 2 at the back of this file, to see the numbers.

☐**Pick your growth percentage per send day**

My starting points, not industry laws: cautious is 10% to 15%, standard is 20% to 30%, fast is 50% and up (only for a clean list on an established domain). You only grow after a green day, so plan for a few hold days on top.

☐**Lock your sending days and time window**

Same days, same time window, every week. Providers learn your pattern, and a steady rhythm is easier to read in your tracker.

☐**Write your go, hold, and scale-back rules and get them approved**

Use the grow, hold, and scale-back table as a starting draft. The rule of the game: decide the thresholds now, while you are calm, and follow them later, when you are not.

Which mailbox provider is this address? (MAGY lookup)

Provider	Consumer domains	Corporate addresses (MX record host)
Microsoft	outlook.com, hotmail.com, live.com, msn.com	MX host ends in mail.protection.outlook.com (Microsoft 365)
Apple	icloud.com, me.com, mac.com	Rare. Also remember Apple Mail Privacy Protection can affect any address read in the Apple Mail app.
Google	gmail.com, googlemail.com	MX host ends in google.com or googlemail.com (Google Workspace)
Yahoo	yahoo.com, ymail.com, rocketmail.com, aol.com (AOL is part of Yahoo)	Rare for corporate addresses

Illustrative numbers, not real data

Say your last 12 sends to your engaged segment had unique click rates between 1.6% and 3.4%, and the median is 2.4%. Your bands are: Success at 2.4% or higher, Watch from 1.8% to 2.3%, Concern below 1.8%. A warm-up send that lands at 2.6% with complaints under 0.1% is a success. A send at 2.0% is a hold, not a disaster.

2 weeks before

Call IT and set up your monitoring

Day -14 to -8

DNS changes take an IT ticket, an approval or two, and time to spread across the internet. Two weeks is the minimum. If your IT queue is slow, file this ticket at the 4 week mark instead.

☐

Send IT the DNS ticket (template below)

SPF, DKIM (usually CNAME records from your ESP), DMARC, your branded tracking or link domain (CNAME), the bounce or return-path domain if your ESP uses one, and the Google Postmaster Tools verification record.

☐

Ask IT for one SPF record only

A domain can have exactly one SPF record. If IT adds a second one instead of editing the first, SPF breaks for everybody. The ESP's `include:` goes inside the existing record.

☐

Start DMARC at `p=none` with a reporting address you can actually read

Google and Yahoo require DMARC for bulk senders. Starting at `p=none` lets you collect reports first and tighten later, once you know every legitimate sender is passing.

☐

Confirm your Google Postmaster Tools access is live (the ticket you opened 2 weeks ago)

Postmaster Tools shows the domain reputation and spam rate that Google actually judges you on. Your ESP's complaint number is not that number. Expect little or no data at low volume; that is normal, so keep checking. If nobody filed that ticket yet, file it today, and expect it to be the slowest item on this whole list.

☐

Sign up for Microsoft SNDS and JMRP, and the Yahoo Complaint Feedback Loop

SNDS and JMRP need a dedicated IP. Apple has no public reputation dashboard, so for Apple you lean on your own bounce, click, and complaint data.

☐

Build your daily tracker

One row per send day, one copy per mailbox provider: sent, delivered, hard bounce %, complaint %, unsubscribe %, unique click %, deferrals, and your decision (grow, hold, or scale back). A printable version is Worksheet 2 at the back of the Word and PDF downloads.

☐

Set your check times

Bounces show up within the hour. Complaints and Postmaster data lag by a day or more. Put a reminder on the calendar for 1 hour and 24 hours after every send, and a third at 48 hours during the first two weeks.

Copy and paste this into your IT ticket

Hi [IT contact],

We are starting to send marketing email from [sending domain] through [ESP name] and need these DNS records live by [date, at least 7 days before launch]:

1. SPF: add [ESP include value] to the existing SPF record for [domain]. Please edit the current record. We can only have one.
2. DKIM: add the DKIM records our ESP generated (attached). They are usually CNAME records.
3. DMARC: add a TXT record at _dmarc.[domain] with policy p=none and reporting address [mailbox you read].
4. Tracking domain: add a CNAME for [links.domain] pointing to [ESP-provided value].
5. Bounce or return-path domain: add the CNAME our ESP provided (if applicable).
6. Google Postmaster Tools: add the TXT verification record (attached).

Please reply as each one goes live so we can test. Thank you so much!

1 week before

Verify everything and rehearse the pause button

Day -7 to -1

Trust nothing until you have tested it. This is the week you find out what IT actually added, not what the ticket asked for.

☐

Send a test to a Gmail address you control and read the raw headers

In Gmail, open the message, click the three dots, and choose Show original. SPF, DKIM, and DMARC should all say PASS, and the DKIM domain should match your From domain.

☐

Confirm the one-click unsubscribe header is in that test message

Look for `List-Unsubscribe` and `List-Unsubscribe-Post: List-Unsubscribe=One-Click`. Google and Yahoo require this for bulk marketing email, and you still want a visible unsubscribe link in the footer.

☐

Check your sending domain and IP against public blocklists

Search your domain and IP in a blocklist lookup tool. A new dedicated IP should be clean, and a reused one sometimes is not.

☐

Send your final email to test addresses at each of the four providers

Check inbox versus spam, mobile rendering, and click every single link. Fix anything odd before it is in front of 500 real people.

☐

Load Tier 1 segments per provider and apply the suppression list

Then count them. The numbers should match your ramp plan for Day 1 through Day 5.

☐

Rehearse the pause

Find the pause, cancel, or throttle control in your ESP. Make sure your owner and backup both have permission to use it, and have both click through it once.

☐

Confirm someone reads the reply-to inbox every day

Replies are a positive signal, and unhappy replies are an early warning that shows up before the complaint numbers do.

☐

Send stakeholders a one-paragraph heads up

Launch date, that the calendar is frozen, who owns go and stop calls, and where they can see progress. Pro tip: include the total number of mailable prospects in your database. Leadership never remembers that number on their own and will ask you for it the moment you mention any of this.

Launch day

Day 0: the first send

Day 0

Small on purpose. The goal of day one is a clean row in your tracker.

☐

Send to Tier 1 only, at your planned starting volume

For a new dedicated IP, a few hundred to about a thousand sends is a common starting point. Split it across the four providers by their share of your list.

☐

Send at the time you will keep using

If your ESP can throttle delivery, spread the send across a window instead of one burst.

☐

Check bounces at 1 hour, then complaints and deferrals at 24 hours

Log every number in the tracker by provider.

☐

Write down the decision before the next send: grow, hold, or scale back

Use the grow, hold, and scale-back table, and note why in one line.

Read before Day 1, use after every send

Grow, hold, or scale back: your rules of the road

Check these numbers at every provider after every send. Any single scale-back trigger wins over any number of green ones. Some thresholds are published by the mailbox providers, and the rest are rules of thumb that I want you to tune for your own list.

Thresholds for each signal, checked per mailbox provider			
Signal	 Grow all true, 2 sends in a row	 Hold any one is true	 Scale back any one is true
Spam complaint rate Published: Google and Yahoo	Below 0.10%	0.10% to 0.19% on one send	0.20% or higher on any send, or 0.10% or higher on two sends in a row. At 0.30% stop sending to that provider and investigate.
Hard bounce rate Rule of thumb	Below 2%	2% to 4%	Above 4%
Unsubscribe rate Rule of thumb	Below 0.5%	0.5% to 1%	Above 1%
Unique click rate vs your baseline Rule of thumb	Success band (at or above baseline)	Watch band (75% to 99% of baseline)	Concern band (below 75% of baseline) on two sends in a row
Deferrals, throttling, and rejections Published: Microsoft	None	Some temporary 4xx deferrals that clear on retry	Sustained deferrals, or any block or permanent rejection (for example Microsoft's 550 5.7.515 for non-compliant bulk mail)
Seed test inbox placement (if you use one) Rule of thumb	Mostly inbox	Some spam-folder placement	Mostly spam folder at one provider. Treat seed tests as directional only.

Small sends need extra care: at 500 delivered, a single complaint is 0.2%. Read small sends by trend and by count across several sends, and do not panic over one percentage from one tiny send.

-  **GROW:** increase to your next planned volume by your chosen percentage.
-  **HOLD:** repeat yesterday's volume, or step back one level, and change nothing else.
-  **SCALE BACK:** start the playbook below, right now.

When the numbers turn

The scale-back playbook

Your numbers just crossed a scale-back line. Breathe, and then work these steps in order. The goal is to leave Spam Jail before the provider decides you belong there.

1 Stop growing today

Do not send a bigger volume than your last green send. Your owner or backup makes the call and writes down the time.

2 Find out where it is failing

Split the numbers by mailbox provider. If only one provider is unhappy, scale back only that provider and keep the others where they are.

3 Cut that provider's volume

Go back to the last volume that was green, or roughly half of where you were, whichever is lower. Send to Tier 1 only.

4 Send your safest send

Use the fallback email you chose three weeks before launch. No promotions, no new content.

5 Pause completely if you hit a hard line

At 0.30% complaints, or blocks and rejections from a provider, pause that provider for 2 to 3 days while you diagnose. A rule of thumb, so ask your ESP if they suggest longer.

6 Diagnose the cause

Use the symptom table that follows these steps. Change one thing at a time so you know what fixed it.

7 Re-ramp slower

Restart at about half of the volume where trouble began, cut your growth percentage in half (for example 20% down to 10%), and require three clean sends in a row before each increase.

8 Ask for help from a human

Contact your ESP's deliverability support first. For blocks, use the mailbox provider's sender support form. Send them your sending domain and IP, the dates, and a few example bounce messages.

9 Write it down

One paragraph in your tracker: what happened, what you changed, what you would do differently. Then update your thresholds.

Symptom, likely cause, and what to do

What you see	Likely cause	What to do
Complaints jump right after you add a new tier	The tier is too stale or never opted in the way you thought	Pull that tier out and re-check where those addresses came from
Hard bounces jump	Old or mistyped addresses	Verify the segment and suppress bounces before the next send
Deferrals at only one provider	Your volume is higher than that provider trusts you with yet	Cut that provider's volume and grow again slowly
Microsoft rejects mail with 550 5.7.515	Non-compliant bulk mail: authentication or required headers are failing	Check SPF, DKIM, DMARC, and alignment; fix and retest before resuming
Clicks drop everywhere but complaints look fine	Content or subject line is not landing	Return to your safest send and test one change at a time
Clicks and inbox placement drop only at Google	Reputation slipping at one provider	Check Postmaster Tools trends, cut volume, keep only Tier 1

Weeks 1 and 2

Best subscribers only, and grow slowly

Days 1 to 14

Some plans put this at roughly 5% to 10% of the total list by the end of week 2. Yours might differ, and that is okay. The rule that does not change: grow only after clean sends.

☐

Send to Tier 1 only, rotating your 2 or 3 evergreen emails

Nothing new in week 1. New audience, new content, and new volume all at once makes it impossible to tell what caused a problem.

☐

Grow by your chosen percentage only after two clean send days in a row

Clean means every metric in the Grow column of the grow, hold, and scale-back table, at every provider you are sending to.

☐

Compare every send to your success bands, by provider

Success, Watch, or Concern. Log it.

☐

Confirm hard bounces suppress automatically, and handle replies the same day

A hard-bounced address you email again is a small self-inflicted wound.

☐

If a provider starts deferring your mail (temporary 4xx errors), hold that provider's volume

Deferrals are a provider telling you to slow down. Do not resend faster to "catch up". Let your ESP retry on its own schedule.

Weeks 3 and 4

Introduce Tier 2, one variable at a time

Days 15 to 28

Volume is higher now, which means bigger consequences. Change one thing at a time so you always know what moved the numbers.

☐

Add Tier 2 only after Tier 1 has been green for a full week

Add it in slices, not all at once, and start with the provider that has looked healthiest.

☐

Change only one of these per send: volume, audience, or content

If you change two, you cannot tell which one caused the problem.

☐

Judge Tier 2 against Tier 2's own history

Its click rate will sit below Tier 1's. That is expected. Hold if it falls into the Watch band, and worry if it lands in Concern twice in a row.

☐

Add a second content type only when the last three sends were steady

A gentle step: another newsletter-style send, not a big promotion.

☐

Check Google Postmaster Tools, Microsoft SNDS, and Yahoo feedback loop data

They lag, so read the trend over several days and not one data point.

Weeks 5 to 8

Tier 3, your normal content, and full volume

Days 29 to 56

Sources describe this stretch as the time you head toward full sending capacity. Your calendar may run longer or shorter than 8 weeks, and a longer ramp is a fine outcome.

☐

Add Tier 3 last, in small slices

Expect lower click rates. Judge them against Tier 3's own baseline and watch complaints and bounces closely.

☐

Bring your normal content mix back, one type at a time

Promotions come back gradually, and never on the same day you add a new audience slice.

☐

Reach target volume, then hold it for two full weeks with everything green

Only then call the warm-up done.

☐

Keep Parked subscribers out of the main stream

Anyone with no activity in 180 days gets their own small re-engagement plan, warmed like a mini launch, and not a sudden blast.

Week 9 and on

Graduation and keeping the reputation you earned

Day 57 and on

Warm-up ends. Reputation upkeep never does.

☐

Confirm two full weeks at target volume with every signal green

Then tell the stakeholders the freeze is over, and update the send calendar with the new normal.

☐

Keep a steady sending rhythm

Long gaps let reputation cool. If you must pause for a while, plan a mini warm-up when you restart.

☐

Move monitoring to weekly and add a quarterly review

Postmaster Tools, SNDS, DMARC reports, bounce and complaint trends. Once your DMARC reports look clean, plan to tighten the policy from `p=none` toward enforcement.

☐

Write a sunset policy

Choose a rule such as: no activity for 180 days means one re-engagement attempt, then suppression. Fewer dead addresses means fewer traps and lower complaint risk.

☐

Save your tracker and notes as the template for the next launch

The next warm-up starts from this one.

Where the numbers come from

Sources and further reading

- Bulk email sender rules for Google, Yahoo, Microsoft and Apple (PowerDMARC)
- What is IP warming? How to warm up a new email IP in 2026 (Knak)
- Email sender guidelines FAQ (Google Workspace Admin Help)
- Apple Mail Privacy Protection: the 2026 guide (Sender)

Mailbox provider rules change, and this list was last checked in September 2026. Confirm current thresholds with each provider before you lock your plan. This checklist is general guidance and is not a guarantee of inbox placement.

Worksheet 1: Baseline

Median unique click rate = the middle value of your last 10 to 12 comparable sends. Success is at or above it. Watch is 75% to 99% of it. Concern is below 75%.

Send date	Audience	Delivered	Unique clickers (bots removed)	Unique click rate

Median: _____ % **Success:** _____ % or higher **Watch:** _____ % to _____ % **Concern:** below _____ %

Worksheet 2: Daily tracker

Make one copy per mailbox provider: Microsoft, Apple, Google, Yahoo. Planned volumes below are an example: start 500, grow 20% per send day, cap 50,000. Replace them with your own plan.

Send day	Planned	Sent	Hard bounce %	Complaint %	Unsub %	Click %	Deferrals	Decision
1	500							
2	600							
3	720							
4	864							
5	1,037							
6	1,244							
7	1,493							
8	1,792							
9	2,150							
10	2,580							
11	3,096							
12	3,715							
13	4,458							
14	5,350							
15	6,420							
16	7,704							
17	9,245							
18	11,094							
19	13,313							
20	15,976							
21	19,171							
22	23,005							
23	27,606							
24	33,127							
25	39,752							
26	47,702							
27	50,000							